Her engagement with women voters, often sharing meals with them across various districts, has struck a chord, boosting the JMM's momentum. She also visited West Singhbhum, holding meetings and roadshows a day before the Odisha CM addressed gatherings in the same district.

One of the JMM's key initiatives, the Maiya Samman Yojana has enrolled 4.8 million women between the ages of 18 and 50, providing a monthly stipend of Rs 1,000. This scheme for women from all communities is being seen as a potential game-changer.

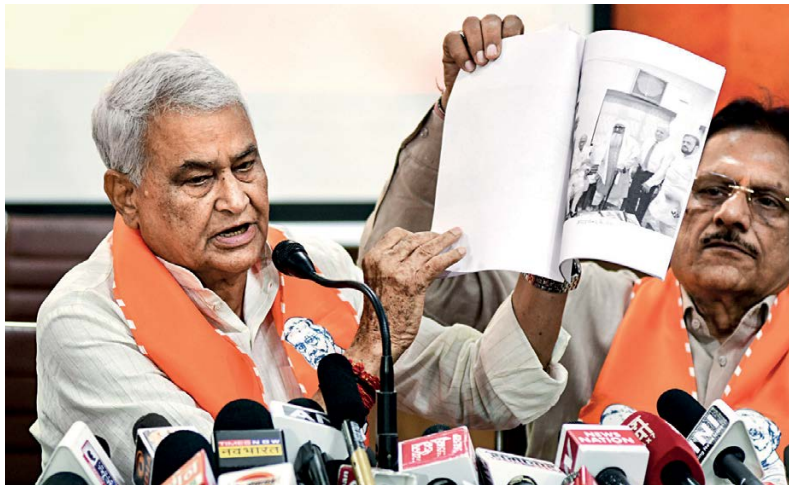


ARUN KUMAR

JMM COUNTERS THE BJP'S BIG OUTREACH WITH ITS MAIYA SAMMAN YATRA, LED BY KALPANA SOREN, MLA AND WIFE OF CM HEMANT SOREN

With non-tribal support crucial for the alliance—given the NDA's clean sweep of all nine non-ST seats in the Lok Sabha polls—the programme could broaden the INDIA bloc's appeal beyond its traditional base.

Soren's administration has introduced major financial relief measures, such as electricity bill waivers, free power and free smartphones. As these welfare schemes compete with the BJP's tribal-nationalist rhetoric, Jharkhand is gearing up for an electoral showdown that could reshape its political future. ■



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MAN ON A MISSION Kirodi Lal Meena addressing the media in Jaipur, Sept. 30

RAJASTHAN

THE BJP DILEMMA

By Rohit Parihar

On September 29, Kirodi Lal Meena—the 72-year-old Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) veteran in Rajasthan—attended a cabinet meeting. Why was that an event? Because it was his first since June 4—the day he put in his papers in a fit of pique, and entered a curious state of limbo with the Bhajan Lal Sharma-led government refusing to accept his resignation. So, when the Sawai Madhopur MLA turned up at the meeting, it sparked speculation that he might withdraw his resignation. But at a press conference the very next day, Meena doubled down on his decision, reiterating his request for Sharma to let him go, a plea that went unanswered.

A seasoned politician with six terms in the Rajasthan assembly and multiple stints in Parliament, Meena's career has been defined by his readiness to take up issues related to corruption and administrative malpractice. His vocal criticism, in fact, played a crucial role in exposing various irregularities in the Ashok Gehlot-led Congress regime. However, after the BJP's victory last December, Meena found himself sidelined—Sharma, a first-time MLA, was chosen as CM, while other younger leaders like Diya Kumari and Prem Chand Bairwa were made deputy CMs. Meena got a not-so-plum portfolio of agriculture.

The BJP's disappointing Lok Sabha poll outing in Dausa and other Meena tribe-dominated constituencies, which had been entrusted to the veteran leader, handed him an honourable excuse to head for the exit door. Since then, he has crisscrossed Rajasthan, submitting memorandums and pushing his agenda on crucial issues. He had showed up at the September 29 meeting mainly to urge his cabinet colleagues to cancel the recruitment exams for sub-inspectors (2021) and Rajasthan Administrative Services (2018), in which he has alleged large-scale irregularities. Even the Special Operations Group (SOG), which is investigating the paper leaks,